

The Ultimate IT Readiness Guide for Egyptian Businesses

A practical guide to CRM, cybersecurity, network infrastructure and call centre deployment — written for businesses operating in Egypt and the wider MENA region.

Six chapters · Checklists, frameworks and templates

Fox Systems · Egypt · Saudi Arabia · Kuwait

How to use this guide

Read the chapter that matches the decision in front of you. Each one ends with something you can act on the same week.

Most IT problems in growing businesses are not caused by bad technology. They are caused by decisions made in the wrong order — buying a CRM before agreeing what a "lead" is, sizing a network for today's headcount, or signing a support contract that does not say what happens at 2am on a Friday.

This guide is organised around those decisions. It does not try to sell you a specific product in every chapter. Where a product category genuinely matters, we say so and explain what separates a good fit from an expensive mistake.

A NOTE ON PRICING

Prices for hardware, licences and bandwidth in Egypt move with exchange rates and import conditions, sometimes sharply. This guide therefore gives you **budget structures, ratios and the questions to ask** rather than figures that would be wrong by the time you read them. Ask any supplier — including us — for a written quote valid for a stated period.

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CRM Selection Framework

How to choose a CRM for your team size, your sector and your language requirements — without paying for software your team will quietly stop using.

Start with the decision the CRM has to support

A CRM is not a database of customers. It is a system for deciding **who gets called next, and why**. Before comparing products, write down the three decisions you want it to make easier. For most businesses those are: which lead an agent should work now, which deals are realistically closing this month, and which customers have gone quiet.

If a product demo cannot show you those three things in ten minutes using your own terminology, it is the wrong product or the wrong configuration — and no amount of training will fix that later.

Sizing: match the system to the team, not the ambition

Team size	What you actually need	Common mistake
1–5 sales staff	Shared contact record, follow-up reminders, one pipeline view.	Buying an enterprise suite and using 4% of it.
6–20	Lead assignment rules, activity logging, basic reporting, role permissions.	No assignment rules — leads sit unowned until someone notices.
21–60	Branch/team scoping, targets, forecasting, duplicate control, audit trail.	Reporting built on data nobody is required to enter.
60+	Territory management, integrations (ERP, telephony), granular permissions, SSO.	Integrations treated as a phase two that never arrives.

The Arabic question

"Supports Arabic" covers two very different things, and the gap between them is where adoption dies:

- **Translated labels.** Menu items appear in Arabic. The layout still runs left-to-right, dates and numbers render awkwardly, and long Arabic strings break tables.
- **True right-to-left.** The whole interface mirrors — navigation, tables, form flow, icons. Arabic text sorts and searches correctly, and names entered in Arabic are findable when typed in Arabic.

Test this with real data, not the demo dataset. Enter a customer name in Arabic, log an activity in Arabic, then search for both. If search fails or the layout jumps, your Arabic-first team will revert to a spreadsheet within a month.

TEST BEFORE YOU BUY

Ask for a trial with **your own exported data** — even fifty rows. Phone number formatting is the usual failure: if the system treats *+201012345678*, *01012345678* and *0020 101 234 5678* as three different customers, you will be cleaning duplicates forever.

Comparison matrix

Score each candidate 0–3 against your own weighting. Anything scoring zero on a row you marked critical is disqualified regardless of total.

Criterion	What "good" looks like
Right-to-left interface	Full mirroring, per-user language, Arabic search works.
Lead routing	Automatic assignment by rule, with a first-response clock.
Duplicate control	Phone normalisation on entry, near-match warning while typing.
Permissions	Enforced in the database, not by hiding menu items.
Telephony integration	Inbound call opens the record; call logged automatically.
Reporting	Answers your three decisions without exporting to Excel.
Data export	Full export in an open format, on demand, without a support ticket.
Local support	Same time zone, same language, named contact, defined response time.
Mobile	Usable one-handed for the two or three things field staff actually do.
Cost at scale	Priced for your headcount in three years, not today.

Questions that reveal more than a demo

1. What happens to our data if we stop paying — can we export everything, and in what format?
2. Who owns the customisations you build for us?
3. Show me the audit log. Who changed this record, and when?
4. If two agents open the same lead at once, what happens?
5. What is the actual response time on a critical issue, in writing?

CHAPTER 01 — ACTION

Write down your three decisions. Score two shortlisted systems against the matrix above using your own data. Do not sign anything until both are scored.

Cybersecurity Baseline Checklist

The controls to put in place first, in the order that removes the most risk for the least money and disruption.

Security spending goes wrong in a predictable way: an expensive appliance arrives before anyone has fixed passwords, backups or patching. The order below is deliberate. Each tier assumes the one above it is done.

Tier 1 — Do this first (low cost, highest return)

- ☐ **Multi-factor authentication** on email, remote access and any admin account. Email is the master key: whoever controls it can reset everything else.
- ☐ **A tested backup.** Not "we have backups" — a restore you have actually performed. Keep one copy offline or otherwise isolated, so ransomware cannot encrypt it too.
- ☐ **Remove dormant accounts.** Every departed employee, contractor and "temporary" admin. Run this monthly; it takes ten minutes.
- ☐ **Patch the internet-facing things** — firewall firmware, VPN appliances, the website. These are scanned constantly by automated tools.
- ☐ **Separate administrator accounts** from daily-use accounts. Nobody reads email as a domain administrator.

THE RESTORE TEST

A backup that has never been restored is a belief, not a control. Pick one file and one server, restore them to a scratch location, time how long it takes, and write the number down. That number is your real recovery time — and it is usually a surprise.

Tier 2 — Once Tier 1 holds

- ☐ **A properly configured firewall.** The appliance is the easy part; the value is in the rules, and in someone reviewing the logs.
- ☐ **Endpoint protection on every device**, centrally reported, including laptops that leave the office.
- ☐ **Segment the network.** Guest Wi-Fi, payment systems, cameras and servers should not share one flat network.
- ☐ **Email filtering** with attachment and link inspection — most incidents still start in an inbox.
- ☐ **Publish SPF, DKIM and DMARC** for your domain so attackers cannot send mail as you. Start DMARC at monitoring, then tighten.

Tier 3 — Maturity

- ☐ Centralised logging with someone accountable for reviewing alerts.
- ☐ A written incident response plan naming who decides to disconnect a system.
- ☐ Annual penetration testing or a vulnerability assessment.
- ☐ Staff awareness training, repeated — once a year does not change behaviour.

Fifteen questions to score yourself

#	Question
1	Is MFA enforced on all email accounts?
2	Have you restored from backup in the last 90 days?
3	Is at least one backup copy isolated from the network?
4	Do you know every device that connects to your network?
5	Is firewall firmware current, and who checks?
6	Are admin accounts separate from daily accounts?
7	Are ex-employee accounts disabled within 24 hours?
8	Is guest Wi-Fi separated from internal systems?
9	Is endpoint protection installed and reporting centrally?
10	Do you have SPF, DKIM and DMARC published?
11	Can you tell who accessed a sensitive file last month?
12	Is there a written plan for a ransomware incident?
13	Are staff trained to report phishing, and do they?
14	Are remote access paths limited and monitored?
15	Does someone own security as part of their job description?

CHAPTER 02 — ACTION

Answer the fifteen questions honestly. Every "no" in Tier 1 is more urgent than any purchase in Tier 2 or 3.

Network Infrastructure Sizing

How to size bandwidth, cabling and wireless for the way your business will work in three years, not the way it worked when the office was fitted out.

Bandwidth: plan for concurrency, not headcount

The question is not "how many people work here" but "how many are doing something demanding at the same moment". A 40-person office where six people are in video calls and everyone else is in email behaves very differently from one running cloud design software.

Activity	Planning allowance per concurrent user
Email, web, CRM and office applications	~1–2 Mbps
Standard video conferencing	~2–4 Mbps
HD video conferencing	~4–8 Mbps
VoIP call (per concurrent call)	~0.1 Mbps plus overhead
Cloud backup / large file sync	Schedule outside business hours

Add the concurrent load, then add **40–50% headroom**. A link running at 90% capacity is not "well utilised" — it is a link where voice quality collapses the moment someone uploads a large file.

CONTENTION AND SLA MATTER MORE THAN THE NUMBER

A 200 Mbps consumer-grade line shared with a neighbourhood will disappoint where a smaller dedicated line with a service level agreement will not. For anything business-critical, ask for the **contention ratio** and the **guaranteed** throughput, not the "up to" figure. Ask what compensation applies when the SLA is missed — the answer tells you how seriously the provider treats it.

Redundancy: decide what an hour of downtime costs

Work out roughly what one hour offline costs you in idle staff, lost orders and support calls. If that number is larger than the monthly cost of a second connection from a different provider, the decision is already made. Ensure the backup genuinely takes a different physical path — two circuits down the same duct fail together.

Cabling: the part you only install once

- **Cat6 or Cat6A** for new installations. The cable is a small part of the cost; the labour and disruption to replace it is not.

- **Two outlets per desk** as a minimum. Desks move and devices multiply.
- **Label both ends** of every run and keep the record updated. Undocumented cabling turns a ten-minute fault into a day.
- **A proper comms room** — ventilated, lockable, with clean power. A rack in a corridor cupboard causes heat-related faults that get misdiagnosed for months.
- **Test and certify** every run on handover, and keep the certificates.

Wireless: coverage is not capacity

Most complaints about "weak Wi-Fi" are capacity problems, not signal problems. One access point serving sixty devices in an open-plan office will show full bars and behave terribly. Plan access points by device density and by how walls are built — plasterboard and concrete behave very differently, and glass partitions reflect more than people expect.

- Separate SSIDs for staff, guests and any device that should never reach internal systems.
- Prefer wired connections for desk phones, printers and anything stationary.
- Run a site survey before buying hardware for anything larger than a single floor.

Branches and remote staff

Decide early whether branches route through head office or go direct to the internet. Backhauling everything through head office simplifies security but makes head office a single point of failure — and adds latency to every cloud application. Whichever you choose, encrypt site-to-site traffic and test failover before you need it.

CHAPTER 03 — ACTION

Count your genuinely concurrent demanding users, apply the table, add 50% headroom, and compare that to what you are paying for now. Then ask your provider for the contention ratio in writing.

Call Centre Setup Roadmap

Deploying a VoIP call centre that customers do not hang up on — from counting seats to writing an Arabic IVR that people can navigate.

Step 1 — Count concurrent calls, not staff

Licensing and trunk capacity depend on how many calls happen **at the same time**, which is usually far lower than headcount — and far higher at predictable peaks. Pull three months of call records and find the busiest hour of the busiest day. Size for that, plus headroom for a campaign.

Step 2 — Decide what the system must do

Capability	Why it matters
IVR / auto-attendant	Routes callers without a receptionist bottleneck.
Queues with announcements	Callers tolerate waiting far better when told their position.
Call recording	Dispute resolution, coaching, and quality review.
CRM integration	The customer record opens as the phone rings — the single biggest time saver.
Reporting	Answer rate, abandonment, average handling time, missed-call follow-up.
Callback	Lets the caller hang up and keep their place. Reduces abandonment sharply.

Step 3 — Get the network right first

Voice is unforgiving. It needs low latency and, above all, consistency. A connection that is fast on average but jittery produces calls that break up — and it is almost always blamed on the phone system.

- Apply **QoS** so voice traffic is prioritised over file transfers and backups.
- Put phones on a **separate VLAN** from workstations.
- Use **wired** connections for agent phones. Wi-Fi for a call centre is a false economy.
- Provide **PoE switches** with enough power budget for every phone, plus spare.
- Put the phone system and switches on **UPS**. Losing phones in a power cut is worse than losing desktops.

Step 4 — Write the Arabic IVR properly

A badly written IVR is worse than no IVR. The rules that matter:

- **Announce the option, then the number:** "للمبيعات، اضغط ١" — people cannot hold a number in mind while listening for what it does.
- **Four options maximum per menu.** Beyond that, callers forget the earlier ones and press zero.
- **Always offer a human.** Trapping people in a menu tree produces angry customers and abandoned calls.
- **Record with a professional voice artist** in Modern Standard Arabic, and keep the same voice throughout. Mixed recordings sound broken.
- **Offer language choice first** if you serve both Arabic and English callers, and remember the choice for known numbers where possible.
- **Keep prompts under ten seconds.** Read them aloud with a stopwatch.

TEST WITH REAL CALLERS

Before going live, have five people who have never seen the menu tree call in with a real task. Watch where they hesitate or press zero. Those are the points to rewrite — not the ones that looked wrong on the flowchart.

Step 5 — Measure the right things

Metric	What it tells you
Answer rate within target	Whether you have enough agents at the right times.
Abandonment rate	How many customers gave up — and by implication went elsewhere.
Average handling time	Useful with context; dangerous as a target on its own.
First-contact resolution	The metric most tied to customer satisfaction.
Missed calls followed up	A missed call nobody returns is a lost sale you paid to generate.

CHAPTER 04 — ACTION

Find your busiest hour from call records, then draw your IVR tree on one page. If it does not fit on one page, it is too complicated for a caller to hold in their head.

IT Budget Planning

A structure for an annual IT budget, and how to present it so a finance director approves it rather than halving it.

Build the budget in five buckets

Bucket	What belongs in it
Run	Connectivity, licences, support contracts, hosting, mobile. Predictable and recurring.
Maintain	Hardware replacement cycle, warranty renewals, spares.
Secure	Security tooling, backup, audits, training. Ring-fence this — it is the first thing cut and the most expensive to have skipped.
Change	New projects: a CRM rollout, a branch fit-out, a migration.
Contingency	A stated percentage for failures and price movement. Without it, every incident becomes a negotiation.

Replacement cycles: budget before the failure

Equipment does not fail on a convenient schedule, but it does fail predictably enough to budget for. Assume a working life and set aside a share of replacement cost each year, so a failure is a scheduled purchase rather than an emergency.

Equipment	Typical planning life
Laptops and desktops	4–5 years
Servers	5–6 years
Network switches	6–8 years
Firewall / security appliances	4–5 years, or when vendor support ends
IP phones	6–8 years
UPS batteries	3–4 years — replace on schedule, not on failure

END OF SUPPORT IS A HARD DEADLINE

When a vendor stops issuing security updates for an appliance, it stops being a security device on that date regardless of whether it still works. Track end-of-support dates in the budget calendar, not in someone's memory.

Currency and import exposure

Any budget with imported hardware in it carries exchange-rate risk. Two practical steps: ask suppliers how long a quote is valid and in which currency, and place large hardware orders early in the budget year rather than deferring them to the final quarter. Where a subscription and a capital purchase are genuinely comparable, the subscription moves the exposure into a predictable monthly figure — which is sometimes worth a higher total cost.

How to present it

Finance directors do not reject IT budgets because the number is large. They reject them because the number is unexplained. Present each line as a risk or an outcome:

- **Not** "firewall renewal" — *"maintains security update coverage; without it the appliance stops receiving patches in March"*.
- **Not** "new laptops" — *"replaces 14 machines past their planning life; current failure rate is costing X support hours per month"*.
- **Not** "CRM licences" — *"supports the sales headcount plan; cost per user falls at the next tier"*.

Where you can, attach a number you already track: hours lost to downtime, support tickets by cause, or leads that went unanswered. A budget defended with your own data is far harder to cut than one defended with a vendor brochure.

CHAPTER 05 — ACTION

List every asset with its purchase year and planning life. Anything already past its life belongs in this year's budget, not next year's emergency.

Vendor Evaluation Scorecard

The questions to ask before signing, and the answers that should end the conversation.

The twelve questions

#	Question	What you are listening for
1	Who will actually do the work?	Named engineers, not "our team". Ask whether it is subcontracted.
2	What is the response time for a critical fault, in writing?	A number and a definition of "critical" in the contract.
3	What happens at 2am on a Friday?	Who answers, and whether that costs extra.
4	Can we speak to a client at our scale in our sector?	Willingness. Reluctance is informative.
5	What is not included?	Good suppliers answer immediately and specifically.
6	Who owns the configuration and data?	You should. Get it in writing.
7	How do we exit, and what does it cost?	Export format, notice period, migration help.
8	What documentation do we receive?	As-built drawings, credentials, licence records — at handover.
9	How are change requests priced?	Rate card agreed up front, not per request.
10	What training is included, and for whom?	Named sessions, and materials you keep.
11	How long is the quote valid, and in which currency?	Matters for anything imported.
12	What has gone wrong on a project like ours?	An honest answer. "Nothing" means they are not telling you.

Answers to walk away from

- **"We'll sort out the details after signing."** The details are the contract.
- **"Everyone uses this."** Not an answer to whether it fits you.
- **"You won't need support, it just works."** Everything needs support eventually.

- **A price far below every other quote.** Something has been excluded. Find out what before, not after.
- **Reluctance to put the SLA in writing.** A verbal service level is not a service level.
- **No named technical contact.** You will be starting from scratch on every call.

Scoring

Score each vendor 1–5 on the criteria that matter to you, weight them, and keep the sheet. Two things make this worth the effort: it forces you to agree internally what matters before a salesperson frames it for you, and it gives you a defensible record of why you chose who you chose.

Criterion	Suggested weight
Technical fit against your requirements	30%
Support model and SLA	25%
Total cost over three years	20%
Relevant references	15%
Exit terms and data portability	10%

CHAPTER 06 — ACTION

Send the twelve questions to every shortlisted supplier in writing, before the next meeting. How quickly and how specifically they reply is itself a data point.

Want a second opinion on any of this?

We install CRM systems, call centres, firewalls and network infrastructure for businesses across Egypt, Saudi Arabia and Kuwait — and we are happy to look at a plan we did not write.

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